

Which World Gets Covered?

Media Ideology and the Geography of Foreign News

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Abstract

Scholarship on foreign news coverage has long assumed that the geographic media coverage converges across outlets, driven by the characteristics of countries and events rather than the politics of the press. We challenge this assumption by arguing that media ideology shapes the symbolic boundaries of political community and, consequently, the geography of foreign news. We expect culturally conservative outlets, which emphasize national identity and express greater skepticism toward globalization, to devote less attention to foreign places and concentrate their international coverage closer to home, whereas economically rightist outlets, whose orientations toward markets and international integration connect domestic politics to developments abroad, should exhibit the opposite pattern. We test these arguments using a novel dataset of one million news articles that are quasi-randomly selected from the Anglophone internet, which comprises 324 major media outlets across 26 countries. The results strongly support our expectations: cultural conservatism is associated with less foreign and more geographically proximate coverage, whereas economic rightism is associated with more foreign and geographically distant coverage. These findings demonstrate that media ideology shapes both political interpretation and geographic news exposure, with significant implications for citizens' geopolitical knowledge, political attitudes, and behavior.

Keywords: media, foreign news, ideology, computational text analysis

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Introduction

Do media outlets diverge in their geographic coverage? If so, how does this divergence arise? These questions carry important implications for how citizens come to understand both domestic and international politics. Citizens depend on the news media as a primary window onto the world around them, particularly distant places (Hayes and Guardino 2013; Rothschild and Shafranek 2017). Beyond simply transmitting information, media shapes public attention through agenda-setting — determining which stories enter the public sphere and which remain invisible — and in so doing, effectively defines the political world that audiences come to know (McCombs and Shaw 1972; Harcup and O’neill 2017). Thus, when outlets differ systematically in which parts of the world they cover, they risk constructing skewed informational environments that leave citizens with unequal and distorted worldviews (Wilke et al. 2012; Segev 2015).

Yet scholarship has paid relatively little attention to how the political character of news organizations shapes which parts of the world receive coverage. Instead, existing work explains geographic news attention primarily through the structural properties of states and their bilateral relationships. Geographic and cultural proximity have long been treated as foundational news values, since journalists are more likely to cover countries that appear closer, more relevant, and less costly to report on (Galtung and Ruge 1965; Westerståhl and Johansson 1994; Jungblut et al. 2024). This framework can also incorporate broader bilateral ties, including trade, military presence, shared language, and political or cultural affinity (Wu 2000, 2007; Jones and Sheets 2009; Jones et al. 2013; Segev 2015). Nevertheless, because this literature focuses mainly on cross-national variation in news flows, it tends to treat the media within each country as relatively uniform, leaving unclear whether and how outlets in the same national context diverge in their geographic attention.

To account for variation across the broader media landscape, we argue that media ideology provides a crucial but overlooked explanation for why outlets within the same national context diverge in their attention to national and foreign places. Media outlets do not simply report on a pre-given agenda; they help define which places, actors, and

events are treated as relevant to domestic political life. News production is therefore an act of boundary-drawing: journalists and editors assess whether an event belongs within their audience’s political community or remains outside it, and media ideology shapes where that boundary is drawn. We further argue that this ideological boundary-drawing operates differently across the cultural and economic dimensions of media ideology. Cultural conservatism tends to narrow the imagined boundaries of political community around national identity (Norris and Inglehart 2019), making foreign affairs appear more distant from the concerns of domestic audiences. As a result, culturally conservative outlets should devote less attention to international affairs and concentrate their foreign coverage on geographically proximate countries. Economic rightism, by contrast, links domestic political life to international markets, trade relationships, and cross-border economic interdependence (Piketty 2020). This orientation gives economically rightist outlets stronger incentives to cover foreign countries more often and broadly.

To test these expectations, we use a novel corpus of one million quasi-randomly selected English-language online articles extracted from Common Crawl (filtered to $N = 425,987$). To capture media ideology, we use measures of the economic and cultural positions of 324 outlets in 26 countries across the world. This study then uses named entity recognition, autonomous gazetteer querying, and a custom algorithm to identify, disambiguate, and geo-code 2,757,820 place references in our corpus. We code whether these place references consist of national versus foreign coverage and the distance of these places from the outlet countries. This measurement strategy allows us to test how ideology corresponds with geographic coverage on a large and almost representative dataset of the Anglophone internet.

Our findings provide strong and consistent support for both sets of expectations. Culturally conservative outlets devote a significantly greater share of their coverage to domestic rather than international stories, compared to their culturally progressive counterparts. When they do cover foreign news, these culturally conservative outlets focus on closer locations. Meanwhile, economically rightist outlets display the opposite pattern — covering foreign news and distant foreign places more often — compared to economically

leftist outlets. Overall, each standard deviation increase in cultural conservatism corresponds to a decrease in the average coverage distance of 550 kilometers (km), whereas a comparable increase in economic conservatism corresponds to an *increased* distance of 737 km. Our results hold consistently across model specifications and are robust to the inclusion of covariates, country fixed effects, outlet clustered standard errors, country/outlet random intercepts, and other specifications.

Broadly, this article makes two primary contributions to the literature on political communication, media ideology, and geographic news coverage. First, it advances research on the geography of foreign news by showing that proximity is not only a fixed structural feature of interstate relations (Galtung and Ruge 1965; Westerståhl and Johansson 1994; Wu 2007; Segev 2015; Jungblut et al. 2024), but also an ideologically conditioned boundary shaped by the worldview of the reporting outlet. Second, it extends media ideology research beyond its usual focus on domestic political content (Larcinese et al. 2011; Puglisi and Snyder Jr 2011; Dotson et al. 2012), showing that ideology also shapes which foreign countries and regions become visible to audiences.

Our findings have important implications for society. When audiences select ideologically congruent outlets (Festinger 1957; Fischer 2011), they also enter geographically-based silos of media content. Conversely, when they select content based on particular regions or place-based stories of interest (Galtung and Ruge 1965; Knobloch-Westerwick 2014) — like a Brazilian election or protests in Minneapolis — they will be exposed to ideologically-skewed media environments. These processes could influence (geographic) political knowledge, political attitudes, and, consequently, political behavior.

The Ideological Foundations of News Coverage

To explain variation in the geographic scope of news coverage, we put forth our argument around the concept of media ideology. Ideology, in its broadest sense, refers to a relatively coherent system of perceptions, meanings, values, and beliefs that functions as a worldview (Williams 1977; Piketty 2020). Applied to news organizations, media ideology refers

to the systematic tendency to select and present information in ways that reflect such a worldview (Shoemaker and Reese 1996; Gentzkow and Shapiro 2006). While variation in media ideology is sometimes overstated (Budak et al. 2016), there are often considerable differences in topic coverage, arguments, framing, and sources across outlets (McCombs and Shaw 1972; Entman 1993). Many prominent outlets have clear ideological positions — such as *Fox* in the US, *The Sun* in the UK, and *Hankyoreh* in South Korea — and many even explicitly endorse political parties along ideological lines (DellaVigna and Kaplan 2007; da Silva 2026).

The ideological character of news organizations may arise from multiple, overlapping sources. At the organizational level, owners and leaders exert influence over editorial lines, whether through direct intervention or by hiring journalists whose orientations align with their own (Herman and Chomsky 1988; Ladd and Lenz 2009). Journalistic backgrounds and professional socialization within newsrooms further shape more routine journalistic decisions that can have ideological implications (Shoemaker and Reese 1996; Groseclose and Milyo 2005). At the market level, outlets also face incentives to cater to the preferences of their audiences, as ideologically segmented readerships reward coverage that confirms their existing worldviews (Dunaway 2008; Gentzkow and Shapiro 2010).

One of the primary methods by which media ideology plays an important political role stems from its influence over which events and places enter the news agenda (McCombs and Shaw 1972). Journalistic decisions about newsworthiness are never purely technical; they inevitably reflect subjective assessments that resist reduction to objective criteria (Donsbach 2004). These assessments, moreover, do not emerge in a vacuum — they are shaped by broader interpretive frameworks that tend to render certain perspectives on the world self-evident while marginalizing others (Hall 1973). Political ideology is one such framework, and we might therefore expect it to color how journalists weigh the relevance and importance of potential stories (McQuail 1993). Even when reporters strive for impartiality, their prior orientations may lead them to overlook events or places that sit outside their ideological frame of reference. The downstream consequences of such selection decisions are substantial: coverage choices construct the informational world

available to audiences and establish which issues and actors acquire political salience (Harcup and O’neill 2017). Systematic patterns in what gets reported — and what does not — therefore carry significant implications for public agenda formation and political evaluation (Boydston 2013).

Empirical research across multiple contexts supports the view that media ideology shapes coverage decisions. For instance, journalists’ personal political beliefs correlate significantly with their news decisions across five democracies (Patterson and Donsbagh 1996). Furthermore, the partisan composition of reporters’ social networks leaves traceable imprints on the stories they produce (Wihbey et al. 2019). These dispositions manifest in systematic patterns of selective attention: partisan alignment predicts how much coverage newspapers devote to unemployment under opposing-party presidents (Larcinese et al. 2011), which party’s scandals receive greater prominence (Puglisi and Snyder Jr 2011), and how extensively ideologically distinct outlets report on issues such as climate change (Dotson et al. 2012).¹

Yet despite this accumulating evidence, existing studies have paid surprisingly little attention to how media ideology shapes geographic coverage.² This is a notable omission given that ideology, at its core, is a worldview: a set of beliefs not merely about domestic arrangements but about the proper relationship between one’s political community and the rest of the world. If media ideology governs which events and actors are deemed relevant or visible, it should shape not only what outlets say about foreign affairs but whether and where they look abroad at all. Whether—and how—media ideology shapes the geographic boundaries of foreign news attention remains largely unexplored.

¹Some studies do caution, however, that outright partisan suppression of opposing viewpoints is difficult to demonstrate (Hassell et al. 2020), suggesting that ideological influence on coverage is real but operates through subtle selection processes rather than overt exclusion.

²Westerståhl and Johansson (1994) demonstrate that ideological context shapes how journalists apply news values such as proximity and importance in foreign news selection, but locate this ideology at the level of national culture rather than individual media organizations.

Two Dimensions of Media Ideology and the Geography of News

Building on the concept of media ideology, we develop a theoretical argument linking outlets' ideological orientations to the geographic scope of their foreign news coverage. Ideology, as we have established, is fundamentally a worldview ([Willnat and Weaver 2014](#)) and a central dimension of any worldview is how it partitions the social world into “us” and “them” ([Tajfel et al. 1981, 1986](#)). Also, individuals interpret foreign actors and their signals through identity-based biases ([Chu and Lee 2024; Han 2025](#)). This partition carries direct consequences for news selection: journalists routinely evaluate whether an event belongs to their community's world or to someone else's, and this judgment shapes not only how foreign events are framed but whether they are selected for coverage at all ([Nossek 2004](#)). Relevance and meaningfulness, in turn, flow from this community membership: events are more likely to be judged newsworthy when they concern actors and places that audiences recognize as part of their world ([Galtung and Ruge 1965; Jones and Sheets 2009; Harcup and O'neill 2017](#)). Also, a historically dominant partition of this kind runs along national lines. As [Anderson \(1983\)](#) argues, the nation is an imagined community, and mass media have played a central role in constructing and sustaining it by synchronizing collective attention around shared domestic affairs. Along with the line of these ideas, we argue that media ideology shapes precisely where these boundaries of relevance are drawn. Specifically, outlets whose worldview is organized around a narrow conception of political community — one that privileges national identity and treats the foreign as peripheral — will systematically attend less to the world beyond their borders than outlets whose worldview encompasses a more internationally oriented sense of collective membership.

Within this broader argument, we distinguish two ideological dimensions that we expect to shape the geographic scope of foreign news coverage in theoretically distinct ways: cultural and economic ideology. Scholars increasingly conceptualize ideology as operating along two distinct axes: the cultural and economic dimensions, as described below. These dimensions are theoretically and empirically separable ([Kitschelt 1994](#);

Kriesi et al. 2006). Their relative salience has moreover shifted as globalization has elevated cultural conflicts about identity and sovereignty alongside longstanding economic divisions, rendering the two axes increasingly orthogonal (Norris and Inglehart 2019). Existing research on media ideology and news coverage has overwhelmingly conceived of ideology as a single liberal-conservative continuum (Groseclose and Milyo 2005; Budak et al. 2016). Distinction between these two dimensions matters for our purposes because cultural and economic orientations imply distinct relationships to the nation, to foreign actors, and to international institutions. They may therefore pull the geographic scope of news coverage in different directions. That is, treating ideology as unidimensional risks obscuring these divergent dynamics and conflating media outlets whose worldviews differ in theoretically meaningful ways.

For the first dimension, cultural ideology refers to positions on the rights, roles, and conditions of socio-cultural groups, encompassing issues such as gender equality, immigration, and national identity (Inglehart 1971; Norris and Inglehart 2019). Cultural conservatism emphasizes traditional social roles, the interests of dominant groups, and nationalism, whereas cultural progressivism emphasizes social equality, the empowerment of marginalized groups, and cosmopolitanism (Kriesi et al. 2006). This cultural dimension bears directly on how news organizations define the boundaries of their political community and, in turn, which parts of the world they deem worth covering. Culturally conservative orientations tend to define political community narrowly — privileging national identity, expressing skepticism toward foreign institutions, and treating domestic affairs as inherently more relevant than international ones (Kumar 2023; Schroeder 2019). Research on foreign news selection supports this logic: studies consistently find that journalists orient their coverage around a domestic “us,” treating foreign events as newsworthy primarily insofar as they impinge on national interests, and that this domestic cultural filter shapes the selection of foreign stories (Nossek 2004).

This logic leads to an expectation regarding the volume of foreign news coverage. Outlets whose ideological orientation is organized around cultural conservatism construct a narrower symbolic boundary of political community — one that privileges national

identity and treats foreign affairs as peripheral to the concerns of their audiences. Because relevance and newsworthiness are filtered through this boundary, culturally conservative outlets should be systematically less likely to select foreign events and places for coverage. Culturally progressive outlets, by contrast, embrace a broader conception of political community — one that extends across national borders to encompass foreign actors, international institutions, and cosmopolitan concerns — and should therefore devote greater attention to the world beyond their borders.

On the other hand, economic ideology refers to positions on redistribution, government spending, and market regulation — the axis that historically formed the primary basis for ideological competition among news outlets (Downs 1957; Lipset and Rokkan 1967). In the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, outlets such as *The Times* and *The Wall Street Journal* aligned with aristocratic or capitalist elites, while others — such as *The Daily Herald* and *L'Humanité* — oriented toward the working class (Chalaby 1998; Kuhn 2006). In terms of worldview, the economic dimension maps onto distinct orientations toward the international order. Economically rightist positions — favoring free markets, capital mobility, and international trade — imply a conception of the relevant economic community that extends well beyond national borders. Economically leftist positions, by contrast — emphasizing domestic redistribution, labor protections, and state intervention — orient attention more narrowly toward the national economic arena, treating international actors and institutions as peripheral to the concerns of domestic audiences.

This distinction carries direct implications for the geographic scope of foreign news coverage. Outlets with more economically rightist orientations embed their audiences in a world where international markets, foreign firms, and global supply chains are directly consequential to everyday economic life. The foreign is not peripheral but constitutive of the economic community their coverage serves. As a result, such outlets have stronger incentives to cast a wider geographic net — tracking developments in distant markets, trade partners, and financial centers that bear on the interests of their readers. Economically leftist outlets, by contrast, are more likely to frame economic life within national boundaries, treating domestic labor, wages, and state capacity as the primary objects

of concern. This inward orientation of economic attention implies a correspondingly narrower geographic scope of foreign coverage, as distant places and international institutions carry less direct relevance for the audiences that these outlets address. Hence, we hypothesize as follows:

***H₁:** Media outlets with stronger culturally conservative orientations are less likely to cover foreign news.*

***H₂:** Media outlets with stronger economically rightist orientations are more likely to cover foreign news.*

Beyond shaping how much outlets cover foreign affairs, media ideology also determines how far into the world their coverage reaches. Geographic distance is not merely a logistical constraint on news gathering but also a symbolic one: the further a place lies from the reporting country, the more cognitive and cultural work is required to render it relevant to domestic audiences ([Galtung and Ruge 1965](#); [Jones et al. 2013](#)). The extensive literature on news proximity consistently finds that outlets devote disproportionate attention to nearby countries, reflecting both the lower costs of coverage and the greater presumed relevance of proximate events to domestic audiences ([Wu 2000](#); [Wilke et al. 2012](#)). Yet proximity is not purely a function of physical distance — it is also filtered through the ideological lens of news organizations, which shapes which parts of the world are deemed close enough to matter. We argue that the cultural and economic dimensions of media ideology generate systematically different orientations toward geographic distance in foreign news coverage.

Culturally conservative outlets, as argued above, define political community narrowly around national identity and treat the foreign as inherently less relevant. This inward orientation should intensify with geographic distance: the further a country lies from the reporting nation, the less it affects the political community of interest as defined by conservatism. Conversely, culturally progressive outlets — whose broader conception of political community extends across national boundaries — are better positioned to render distant places relevant to their audiences, as cosmopolitan orientations reduce the

symbolic friction of covering far-away events. We therefore expect culturally conservative outlets to concentrate their foreign coverage on nearby countries and to underrepresent more distant parts of the world.

The economic dimension, by contrast, implies a different relationship to geographic distance. Economically rightist outlets are oriented toward international markets, trade, and capital flows — economic relationships that frequently span large distances and connect domestic audiences to geographically remote partners. For such outlets, distance does not diminish the relevance of foreign coverage so long as distant places remain economically consequential. Indeed, major financial centers, commodity producers, and trading partners — like Chinese manufacturers for American markets — are often geographically far from the reporting country and their economic significance gives economically rightist outlets strong incentives to cover them. Economically leftist outlets, focused on domestic redistribution and national economic capacity, have weaker reasons to follow developments in distant markets. We therefore expect economically rightist outlets to be more likely to cover geographically distant countries than their leftist counterparts.

H₃: Media outlets with stronger culturally conservative orientations are less likely to focus their foreign news coverage on geographically distant countries.

H₄: Media outlets with stronger economically rightist orientations are more likely to focus their foreign news coverage on geographically distant countries.

Data and Methods

Data

To test our hypotheses, we construct a large corpus of online media content from Common Crawl, a repository of almost all permitting³ internet web pages, and its “Common Crawl News” subset of online news and opinion articles (Nagel 2016). We use *news-please*,

³Web pages that prohibit crawling through *robots.txt* restrictions are excluded for legal purposes.

an open-source news crawler, to extract articles from this repository (Hamborg et al. 2017). To improve the representativeness of the corpus, we modify the Python version of *news-please* to collect quasi-randomly selected articles across the full period available at the time of data collection, from October 2016 to March 2024. We also restrict the corpus to English-language articles, which improves comparability in the measurement of media ideology and geographic coverage. Furthermore, distinguishing between millions of place names across multiple languages would be infeasible. Although this restriction limits external validity beyond English-language media, English is by far the most common language on the internet, accounting for roughly 42% of Common Crawl content (CommonCrawl 2026).

We then clean the corpus in several steps. First, we remove texts with fewer than 100 tokens, which we consider too short to constitute full articles. Second, we exclude outlets with fewer than 400 articles to ensure that outlet-level ideological measures are based on sufficient textual evidence. Third, we remove articles incorrectly labeled as English by Common Crawl. Fourth, we eventually remove articles without at least 20 economic-related and 20 cultural-related articles to have reliable ideology scores. After these filters, the final dataset contains 425,987 articles from 324 major outlets across 26 countries in all populated continents.

Several appendices provide more information about the dataset: Appendix A includes a list of outlets by country; Appendix B displays the distribution of articles across time and place; and Appendix C provides example articles.

Measuring Geographic Coverage

This study develops a novel procedure to measure the geographic scope of media coverage. We construct two dependent variables corresponding to our hypotheses: (1) the proportion of places mentioned in an article that are located within the outlet’s country, used to test H_1 and H_2 , and (2) the average distance between a foreign mentioned place and the outlet’s country, used to test H_3 and H_4 .

We identify toponyms in several steps. First, we use *spaCy*’s Named Entity Recog-

nition model to detect likely place names in the article corpus (Honnibal et al. 2020). This allows us to distinguish place names from homonymous non-place references, such as “Chad” when used as a person’s name rather than as the country. We then query the detected toponyms in the GeoNames gazetteer, which contains more than 5.7 million location names along with coordinates, country identifiers, population sizes, and other metadata (GeoNames 2026). This includes countries, provinces/states, counties, and cities. Since countries often have various English-language names, including official names, common names, abbreviations, and demonyms, all of these are included. Thus, references to Arab Republic of Egypt,” Egypt,” Egyptian,” and Egyptians” are all matched to Egypt. We define geographic coverage as explicit references to countries and subnational places; mentions of people or organizations are not assigned to a location unless the text also contains a geographic reference. This procedure yields 2,757,820 toponym mentions across the article corpus.

Next, we disambiguate homonymous place names using a custom algorithm. When a toponym could refer to multiple places, such as San Juan in Puerto Rico or Argentina, the algorithm assigns the location from the country with the largest number of other toponyms in the same article. To reduce ambiguity created by the large number of small places in GeoNames, we retain only places with populations above 100,000, along with all countries. As this could introduce bias, Appendix D performs our analyses using only countries, so that no places are removed. These results are largely similar to our main results. When two places within the same country share a name, such as São Paulo state and São Paulo city in Brazil, the algorithm assigns the location with the larger population, which is normally in the same area.

Figure 1 displays an example text along with a visual illustration of how spaCy, GeoNames, and our algorithm together identify and geo-code toponyms. It demonstrates how homonymous non-toponyms are excluded and how homonymous toponyms are disambiguated.

GeoNames provides the country of each toponym. We then create a variable that indicates if the toponym is in the same country (or is the country itself) as the outlet

Figure 1: Example of Geo-Coding Process

(a) Example Text and spaCy Named-Entity Recognition

Justin Trudeau and Katy Perry ate a turkey sandwich in Turkey last week. They then travelled home to Canada. Confidential sources claim that they drove throughout Ontario yesterday and finished the trip in London. Today, they are set to attend a political studies conference in Oxford.

(b) Geo-Coding with GeoNames

	turkey, canada, ontario, london, oxford				
country					
location	38°57'N, 35°14'E	61°04'N, 107°59'W	50°00'N, 85°00'W	42°59'N, 81°14'W	51°45'N, 1°15'W
national	×	×	×	×	×
western	×	✓	✓	✓	✓

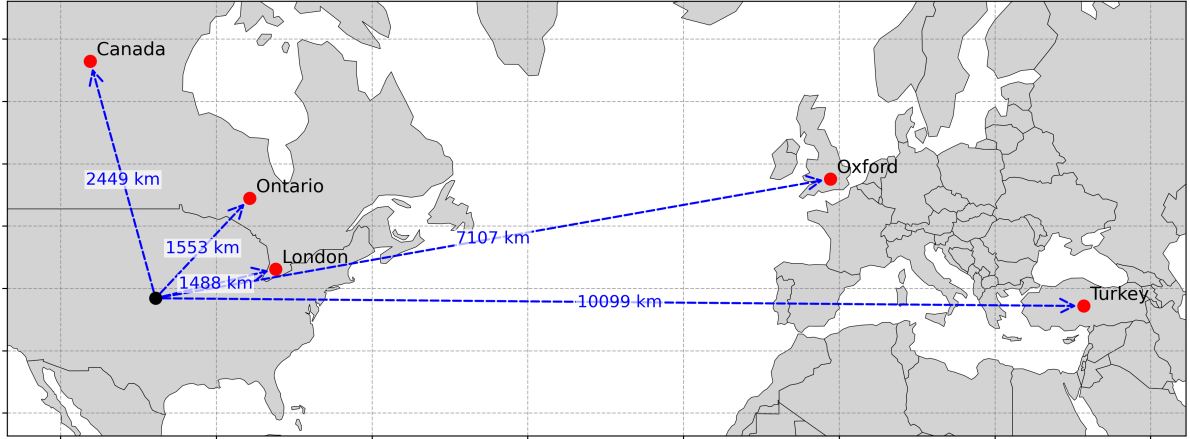
mentioning it (“national”). GeoNames also provides the coordinates of the centroid of each location. For example, for California, the coordinates are slightly north of Fresno. We calculate the distance in kilometers (“distance_km”) between each foreign toponym’s centroid and the outlet country’s centroid. Distance is calculated using the Haversine Formula, which accounts for the Earth’s curvature when calculating distances:

$$d_p = 2R \arcsin \left(\sqrt{\sin^2 \left(\frac{lat_p - lat_o}{2} \right) + \cos(lat_o) \cos(lat_p) \sin^2 \left(\frac{lon_p - lon_o}{2} \right)} \right)$$

where d is distance, p is place mention, R is Earth’s radius (6371 km), lat is latitude, lon is longitude, and o is outlet. Figure 2 displays this visually. Since this variable is susceptible to skew, we log-transform it (“log_dist”).

Articles about one place sometimes mention other places, like an article about Paris that mentions immigrants from Morocco. However, we consider these references to be an important part of geographic coverage. In other words, an article about Moroccan

Figure 2: Example Distance Calculations



immigration to Paris is about both Paris and Morocco. Therefore, both of our dependent variables explicitly capture these places. The number of place mentions in the setting (e.g., Paris) usually compensates for lower amounts of other toponyms (e.g., Morocco).

Because the distance of foreign coverage depends partly on an outlet's home country, cross-national comparisons may reflect differences in country size, geographic location, or proximity to other states. Our primary models therefore include outlet-country fixed effects, ensuring that culturally and economically distinct outlets are compared within the same national context. The estimated relationships thus capture whether media ideology is associated with covering relatively nearer or more distant foreign places among outlets facing the same country-level geographic conditions.

We aggregate these toponym-level measures to the article level to construct the dependent variables. For H_1 and H_2 , we calculate the share of all toponyms in each article that are located in the outlet's country. This measure captures the extent to which an article's geographic coverage is national rather than foreign. For H_3 and H_4 , we focus only on foreign coverage by removing all toponyms located in the outlet's country. For example, if an article from a British outlet mentions Liverpool and Kerala, only Kerala remains; if the same article were published by an Indian outlet, only Liverpool would remain. We then calculate the average logged distance between the centroid of the outlet's country and all foreign places mentioned in the article. This measure captures how

geographically distant an outlet’s foreign coverage is.

Measuring Media Ideology

Our study also requires outlet-level measures of cultural and economic ideology, which serve as the independent variables for all four hypotheses. We use measurements from [Author \(2026b\)](#), the only media ideology dataset that differentiates between cultural and economic ideologies at scale (to our knowledge). The ideological measurement strategy is described in greater detail in Appendix E. Briefly, it consists of three steps.

First, this study identifies which articles address cultural or economic issues using BERT and GPT-3.5 Turbo. There are 85,592 economic articles (18.1%), 77,398 cultural articles (16.4%), and 309,181 non-political articles (65.5%).

Second, this study classifies the ideological positions of each relevant article using GPT-4o-mini and a novel media ideology classification method called “Multi-Cue Classification,” which is described and validated in [Author \(2026a\)](#). Economic articles are coded as leftist, centrist, or rightist, while cultural articles are coded as progressive, centrist, or conservative.

Third, the author aggregates article-level classifications to the outlet level. Scores are standardized, with higher scores denoting more rightist/conservative outlet positions.

LLM prompts are displayed in Appendix F and ideological criteria are explained in Appendix G. All classifications are validated with human expert coding in [Author \(2026a\)](#), Appendix H (confusion matrices), and Appendix I (classification performance metrics).

Modeling

To test the relationship between outlet ideology and geographic coverage, we estimate a series of regression models using the two article-level datasets described in Section . Because H_1 and H_2 both examine the proportion of national coverage as the dependent variable, we test them jointly in models that include outlets’ cultural and economic posi-

tions simultaneously. This allows us to estimate the association between each ideological dimension and geographic coverage while holding the other constant. We use the same strategy for H₃ and H₄, which share “logged foreign coverage distance” as the dependent variable. The baseline specification is therefore:

$$DV_{ij} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{cult}_j + \beta_2 \text{econ}_j + \varepsilon_{ij},$$

where DV is dependent variable, i indexes articles, j indexes outlets, cult is the cultural position, and econ is the economic position.

For each set of hypotheses, we estimate five primary model specifications. The first specification regresses the dependent variable only on outlets’ cultural and economic positions. The second adds article-level controls for date-time and word count, as well as outlet-level controls for whether the outlet is based in a Western country and outlet size, measured as the logged number of political articles published in our corpus. The remaining specifications include the same covariates. The third adds outlet-origin country fixed effects. The fourth includes these country fixed effects and clusters standard errors by outlet. The fifth estimates a multilevel model with random intercepts for countries and outlets.

We also conduct several robustness checks in Appendices D (only country toponyms), H (only political articles), and I (segmenting by Western/non-Western outlets). Appendix L adds three additional outlet-level covariates indicating whether outlets are local news organizations, tabloids, or publicly owned, since these variables may form sub-country media markets ([Shoemaker and Reese 1996](#)). These results are largely consistent with those in Section below. Since H₁ and H₂ have proportions as dependent variables, Appendix M displays Papke-Wooldridge fractional response models with country fixed effects and outlet-clustered standard errors.

Results

Before testing the hypotheses, we present descriptive evidence on the geographic distribution of coverage in our corpus. Figure 3 maps the overall distribution of geographic references. Panel A shows national coverage and Panel B shows foreign coverage.

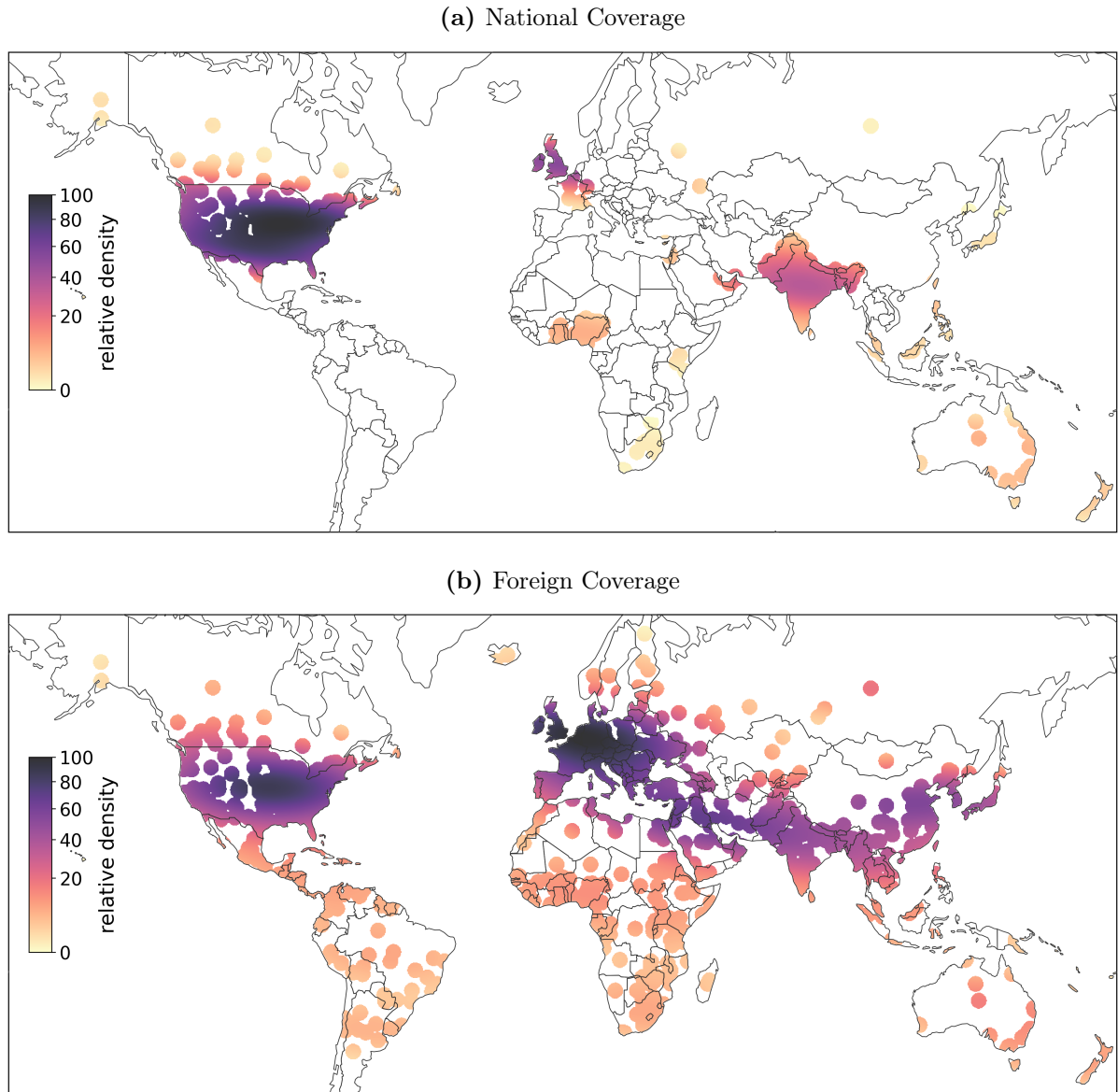
Panel A shows that national coverage is especially concentrated in the United States, followed by the United Kingdom, Ireland, India, several South Asian countries, and a smaller set of other countries. Since our corpus consists of English-language articles, the Anglophone world and countries with large English-speaking populations are unsurprisingly prominent. Panel B indicates that foreign coverage is also concentrated in the Anglosphere, while extending more broadly to continental Europe and parts of Asia without English-language legacies.

Second, Figure 4 summarizes the descriptive relationship between outlet ideology and coverage distance overall. The figure reports the change in average coverage distance associated with a one-standard-deviation increase in cultural conservatism and economic rightism. In this case, we include all toponyms, rather than only foreign coverage, and uses distance in kilometers rather than logged distance. It is intended to show the simple association between ideology and geographic coverage distance, both overall (“Simple”) and within countries (“FE”). Because cultural conservatism and economic rightism are strongly correlated, each estimate controls for the other ideological dimension.

The descriptive patterns are consistent with our expectations. On average, outlets that are one standard deviation more culturally conservative cover places approximately 506-550 kilometers closer to home. By contrast, outlets that are one standard deviation more economically rightist cover places approximately 737-831 kilometers farther away.

We now turn to hypothesis testing. H_1 and H_2 predict that the cultural and economic ideology of outlets influences the proportion of their coverage that is devoted to national versus foreign affairs. Figure 5 displays five models that test these propositions, as described in Section . We find strong and consistent evidence for a relationship between media ideology and national versus foreign coverage. Cultural conservatism is positively associated with national coverage, whereas economic rightism is negatively as-

Figure 3: Heatmap of Geographic Coverage of English-Language Articles

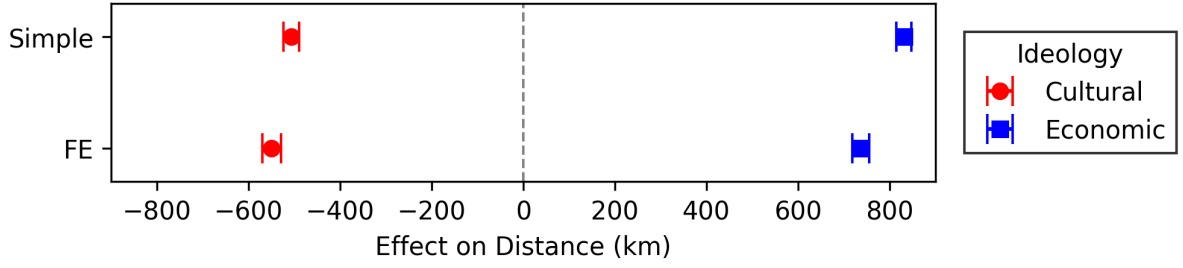


Note: Due to computational limits, both panels are based on random selections of 20,000 toponyms out of 1,517,636 (national coverage) or 1,240,184 (foreign coverage).

sociated with national coverage. These patterns are robust across model specifications. All ideological coefficients are statistically significant at $p \leq 0.001$.

Substantively, these results indicate that a one-standard-deviation increase in cultural conservatism is associated with a 2.6 to 5.2 percentage point (ppt) increase in the proportion of national coverage. By contrast, a one-standard-deviation increase in economic rightism is associated with a 5.5 to 10.8 ppt decrease in national coverage. Thus, cul-

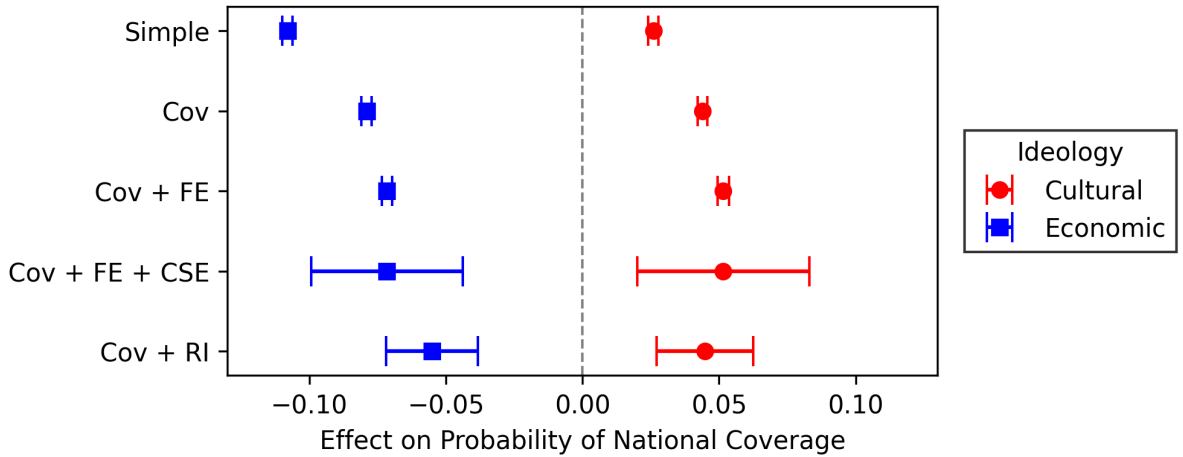
Figure 4: Descriptive Association between Ideology and Overall Coverage Distance



Note: The dependent variable is the average distance in kilometers between an outlet country's centroid and all toponyms in an article. The independent variables are the standardized cultural and economic ideological positions of the outlets. Dots are coefficients and whiskers are 95% confidence intervals. "FE" is country fixed effects.

turally conservative outlets pay more attention to domestic places, whereas economically rightist outlets pay relatively more attention to foreign places.

Figure 5: Testing the Effects of Ideology on National-versus-Foreign Coverage (H_1 - H_2)



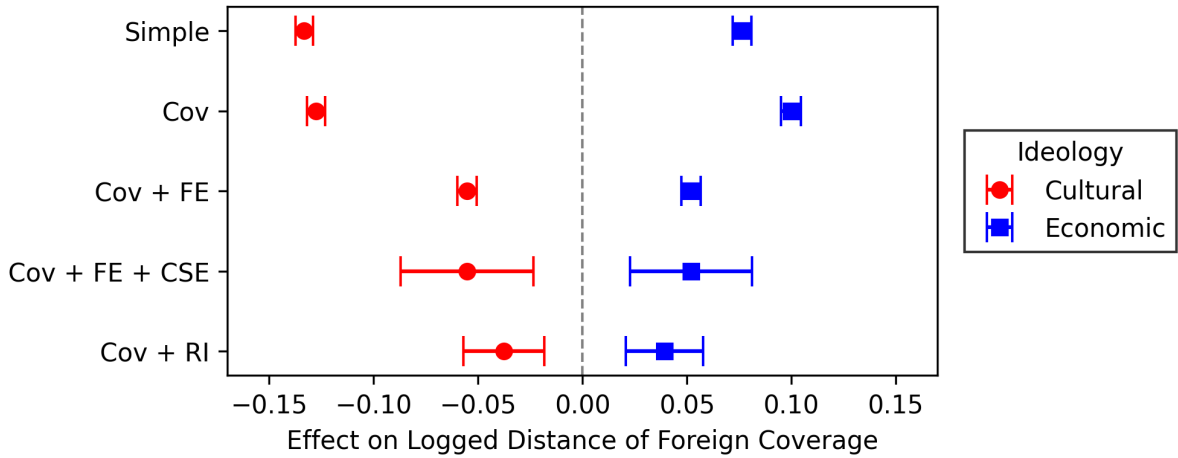
Note: The dependent variable is the average proportion of an article's coverage that focuses on places within the outlet's country. The independent variables are the cultural and economic ideological positions of the outlets. Dots are coefficients and whiskers are 95% confidence intervals. "Cov" is the covariates, "FE" is country fixed effects, "CSE" is article clustered standard errors, and "RI" is outlet and country random intercepts.

Finally, we test H_3 and H_4 , which predict that when outlets do cover foreign places, their cultural and economic ideologies shape the geographic distance of those places from the outlet's home country. Figure 6 reports the results using the same five model specifications as in Figure 5. The results again provide strong support for our hypotheses.

Cultural conservatism is associated with shorter-distance foreign coverage, whereas economic rightism is associated with longer-distance foreign coverage. These relationships are consistent across all specifications, although the coefficient sizes vary somewhat, especially between models that do and do not account for country-level variation. As before, all ideological coefficients are statistically significant at $p \leq 0.001$.

Because the dependent variable is *logged* distance in kilometers, the coefficients can be interpreted approximately as percent changes in distance associated with a one-unit (standard deviation) increase in the independent variable. Substantively, a one-standard-deviation increase in cultural conservatism corresponds to a 3.8 to 13.3 ppt reduction in the average distance of foreign coverage. By contrast, a one-standard-deviation increase in economic rightism corresponds to a 3.9 to 10.0 ppt increase in the average distance of foreign toponyms.

Figure 6: Testing the Effects of Ideology on Foreign Coverage Distance (H₃-H₄)



Note: The dependent variable is the logged average distance in kilometers between all toponyms in an article and the outlet's country centroid. See Figure 5 for other variables, symbols, and abbreviations, which are identical.

Appendix N includes regression tables with all covariates for the models displayed in Figures 5 and 6. Appendices D, J, K, L, and M consist of robustness checks (described in Section). These results all have the same statistical significance levels ($p \leq 0.001$) and directions as those displayed above, indicating robustness to diverse specifications.

Discussion

For most citizens, the political world is not understood through direct experience, but through mediated accounts. This article argues that media ideology shapes which parts of the world become visible in the news by structuring the symbolic boundaries of political community. Decomposing ideology into cultural and economic dimensions, we hypothesized that culturally conservative outlets devote less attention to foreign places and focus closer to home, whereas economically rightist outlets display the opposite pattern. Using a novel dataset of global online news articles, LLM-based ideology measures, and new methods of computational geocoding, we find support for these expectations: ideological differences among domestic media outlets produce systematically distinct geographic information environments.

Broadly, our findings speak to several important bodies of scholarship in political science and communication. The first concerns the determinants of foreign news coverage. Existing research has made considerable progress in explaining cross-national variation in news flows by pointing to national traits ([Wu 2000](#); [Segev 2015](#)), international relational factors ([Galtung and Ruge 1965](#); [Jones et al. 2013](#)), and event-level characteristics ([Shoemaker and Cohen 2012](#)). Yet this literature has largely treated national media systems as homogeneous actors, offering limited leverage for understanding within-country variation in geographic news attention. Our study addresses this gap by demonstrating that ideological differences among outlets operating within the same national context produce divergent geographic agendas. Moreover, by extending research on domestic media ideology to an international context, we reassess the prevailing expectation that foreign affairs coverage converges across outlets. Although indexing theory ([Bennett 1990](#)) and the cascading activation model ([Entman 2003](#)) suggest that foreign reporting clusters around shared elite narratives, our findings show that convergence may not extend to agenda selection. Ideological differences also shape which parts of the world outlets choose to cover.

These findings carry important political implications. Citizens whose ideologically-filtered media environments systematically underrepresent certain regions may therefore

be less able to evaluate policy decisions concerning those regions, less responsive to appeals for international solidarity, and more vulnerable to elite framing that exploits informational gaps. Geographic patterns of selective exposure may also place audiences seeking coverage of particular regions or events in ideologically skewed information environments, where exposure to unfamiliar viewpoints can shape political attitudes, behavior, and voting (DellaVigna and Kaplan 2007; da Silva 2026).

This study also has several limitations that point to promising directions for future research. First, our dataset includes only English-language articles. Although this restriction improves internal validity by making measurements more comparable across outlets, it limits the generalizability of our findings to non-English media environments. Future work could therefore examine whether the relationship between media ideology and geographic coverage extends across languages and national contexts. Second, our observational design identifies associations but cannot establish causality. Because media ideology is difficult to manipulate experimentally, future research could exploit ownership or institutional changes to strengthen causal inference quasi-experimentally. However, in this paper, we are interested in the association between media ideology and geographic coverage partly due to the segmented media environments that these relationships create, regardless of causality. Third, our measure captures explicit place references but may overlook geographic attention conveyed indirectly through mentions of people or organizations associated with particular countries. Future research could extend this approach by linking such entities to their geographic affiliations, providing a broader measure of how places enter news coverage. Finally, we examine *where* outlets direct their attention rather than *what* they say about those places. Although ideology probably shapes the framing, tone, and sentiment of geographic references (Entman 1993), these questions fall beyond the scope of this study. Future research could combine measures of geographic attention with textual analysis to examine how media ideology shapes both the distribution and content of coverage.

These and other valuable extensions of our current work could make further contributions to the literatures of political communication, media ideology, and geographic

coverage.

Note for Reviewers

Some of the content of the appendices is also included in other papers that are currently under review at journals. It is provided in the appendices of this paper so that reviewers can refer to this content easily. At a future point, we may edit or remove duplicated parts of these appendices and refer instead to the other papers.

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